

Local News

B.C. mines ministry investigating pollution from old Vancouver Island mine

Amy Smart • Victoria Times Colonist
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The face of the tailings dump of a long-abandoned mine near the Jordan River is crusted with green scabs. PNG

VICTORIA — B.C. Mines Minister Bill Bennett says he doesn't know why a high-risk mine site leaching copper into southern Vancouver Island's Jordan River was deemed clean by the province in 1993.

The now-defunct Sunro Mine and surrounding area has been identified as the source of copper contamination in the river, which once supported thousands of salmon. The fish numbers are much lower today, and the river banks don't have much vegetation.

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The problem came to the province's attention through the work of concerned citizen Ken Farquharson, who spearheaded efforts to identify a responsible party, to complement other efforts to bring salmon back.

"I don't know why. I had no way of knowing, my staff are researching and trying to figure that out. But whatever the research turns up, there's no excuse for it," Bennett said.

"I don't think the government should be trying to excuse the mistake, which is obviously what it was. And we're certainly appreciative of the fact that a citizen took it upon himself to dig into this and bring it to the government's attention."

Evidence today shows contamination, but a mine inspector under Mike Harcourt's NDP government issued a letter in 1993 stating, "final reclamation carried out and found satisfactory," a report by SNC-Lavalin, commissioned by former site owner Teck Resources Ltd., found.

After a site is deemed clean, no further inspections are typically conducted, Bennett said.

Cominco, now owned by Teck, acquired mining rights to the area in 1919 and leased them to other companies over the years. Mining occurred on and off, with about 600,000 tonnes of ore mined between 1949 and 1950 and about 1.3 million tonnes mined or milled between 1962 and 1974. The land was returned to the Crown in 1993, after cleanup was deemed satisfactory, and now belongs to Western Forest Products.

For more on this story, check out the [Times Colonist](#)



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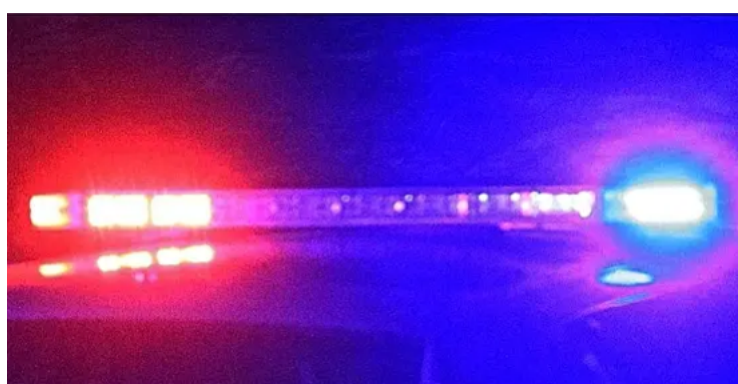
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